Landowners into Bureaucrats

Enfranchisement and Local Administration in the Russian Empire

Igor Kolesnikov (UC Berkeley) · **Otto Kienitz** (SNF Agora, Johns Hopkins)

igorucb.github.io

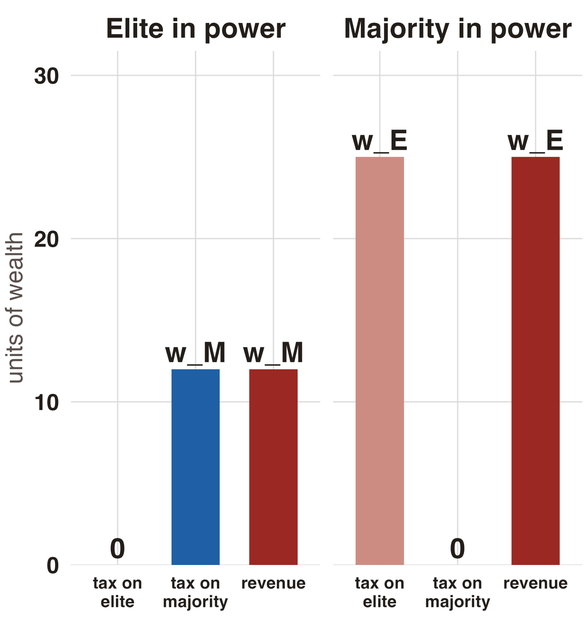
1. Highlights

- Building an administration is hard: good officials are expensive and **selecting** them is costly. Representative institutions and effective states cluster together, but causally in which direction?
  - Besley & Persson (2011); Acemoglu & Robinson (2000)
- **This paper asks whether large-scale enfranchisement can draw high human-capital individuals into the state and so build bureaucratic capacity** — using Russia's 1864 zemstvo reform.
- Russia's **1864 zemstvo reform** did two things at once:
  - **Enfranchisement** — in place of fully noble legislatures, elected assemblies with varying representation for landowners, rich urbanites and peasant communes.
  - **Fiscal decentralization** — the new assemblies could tax **all immovable property**: noble land, factories, communal peasant allotments
- **Hypothesis.** Enfranchising the poor enlarges the tax base by shifting the burden onto the rich. A bigger pie gives each elite member a private incentive to take office and capture part of it **via rents**.

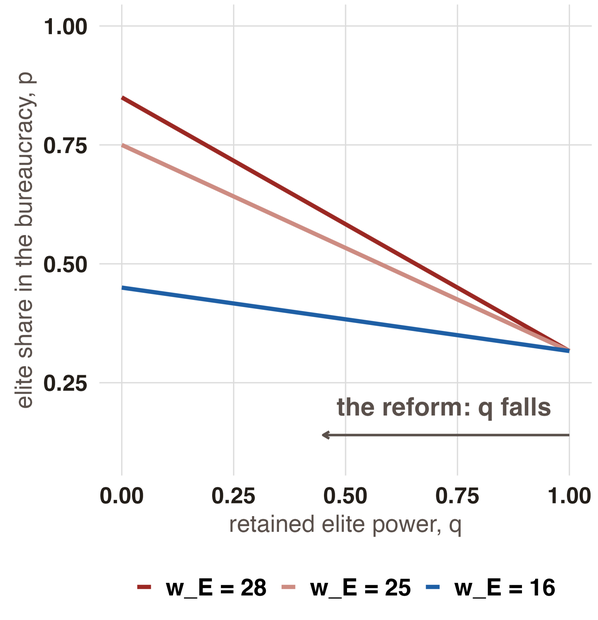
Enfranchise the majority → **Local revenue (+)** → **Elite entry into office** → **Bureaucratic development**

Member i enters iff $\varepsilon_i \le \rho\, R(q)$, $R(q) = q \cdot w_M + (1-q) \cdot w_E \implies \partial p / \partial q < 0$

q = probability the elite retains the assembly; p = share of the elite in the bureaucracy; ρ = rents. Whoever controls the assembly sets the budget and hands part of it to the officials who run it. The gradient is steeper where the elite is richer.



Each group taxes the other. Because $w_E > w_M$, a majority in power raises more.



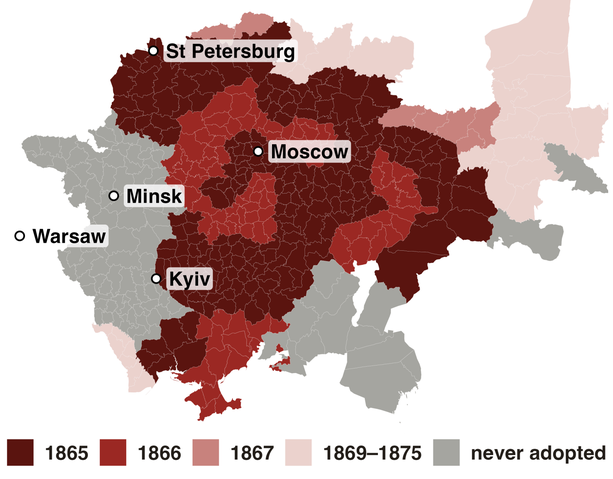
Entry rises as the elite loses power, fastest where the elite is rich.

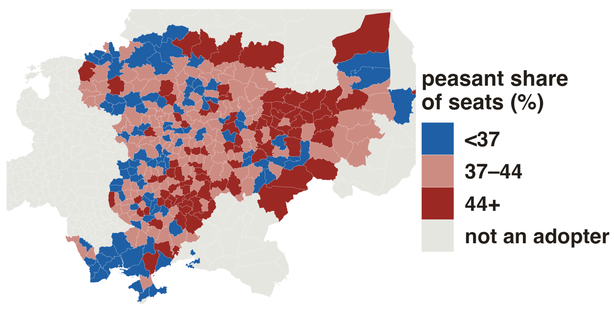
2. Data

- **The elite.** The 19,000 richest landowners (21,000+ estates with 100+ male serfs); hereditary nobility ennobled before 1863.
- **Local leadership** — the legislators who drafted the Great Reform and the **peace arbitrators**, esteemed officials tasked by the local nobility with implementing the abolition of serfdom: 1,183 + 2,939 = **4,122 men**.
- **The bureaucracy.** *Senatskie vedomosti*, the gazette of appointments, promotions and dismissals. LLM pipeline over 1860–1876: **692,615 records → 168,189 personnel events** in the 432 panel districts.
  - 28,705 entries · 8,631 transfers · 10,373 exits. Matched to landowners by phonetic surname.
- **Fiscal policies (tax and spend) of the new assemblies.** Balance sheets of **215 noble estates (1873)**; budgets of 30 provincial zemstva.

3. Empirical strategy

- **Treatment:** opening of a district assembly — nobles lost at least half the seats.
- **Rollout:** staggered, 336 districts 1865–1875; 96 never adopt.
- Archival records let us **reconstruct the seat formula for all three curiae** and reproduce the printed 1864 schedule.





The **dose**: the peasant curia's statutory share of the assembly, three bands over the 336 adopters.

$$Y_{it}(0) = \alpha_i + \beta_t + \Sigma_k\, \gamma_k (yr_t \times \hat{s}_{ki})$$
$$\hat{\tau}_{it} = Y_{it} - \hat{Y}_{it}(0)$$

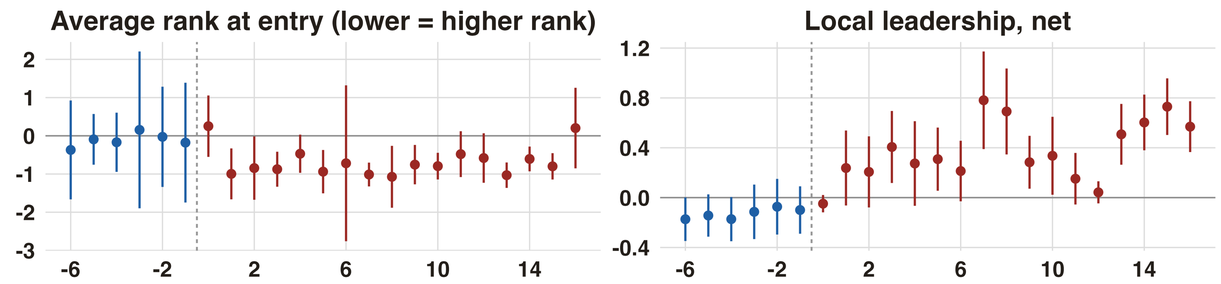
BJS imputation on untreated cells. District and half-year fixed effects; $\hat{s}_k$ = three **predicted curia shares** × year trend. Not-yet-treated controls; SE clustered by province (34).

Key assumption. Conditional on the predicted seat allocation, treated and not-yet-treated districts were on parallel paths.

4. Results

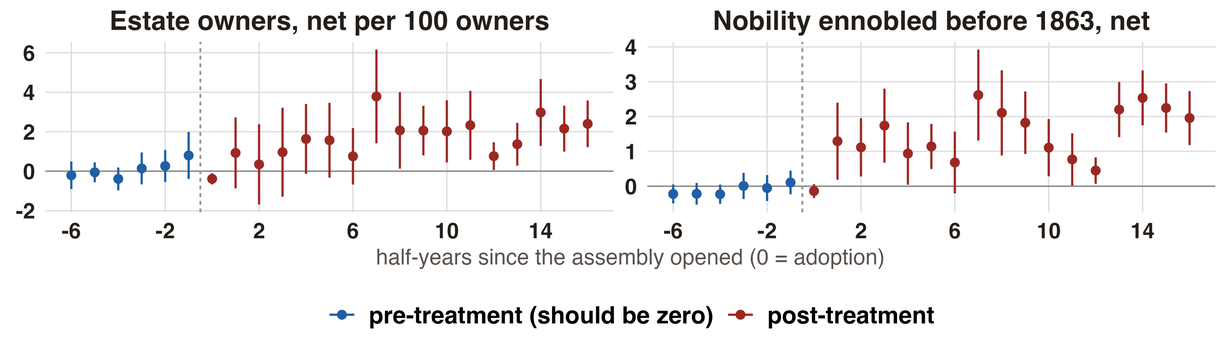
All outcomes are **net**: entries + transfers − exits, within the same match category. BJS imputation; 95% intervals clustered by province.

Quality of the bureaucracy: the officials who enter bring more experience. More of them come from the **local leadership** — the men who drafted the emancipation and then implemented it. In the Table of Ranks **1 is the top** and 14 the bottom; a lower number marks a more senior post, earned by achievement or by years of service. So a fall in the average rank at entry means more experienced men are arriving.



Flat before, moving after. Each treated cell's counterfactual is imputed from untreated cells, then averaged by horizon.

Bureaucratic mobilization: the reform tapped the local elite. Estate owners are former serf owners holding more than 100 serfs — the political and economic elite of the empire.



$$\hat{Y}_{itr}(0) = \hat{\alpha}_{ir} + \hat{\beta}_{tr} + \Sigma_k\, \hat{\gamma}_{kr} (yr_t \times \hat{s}_{ki}) \qquad \hat{\tau}_r = \text{mean}_{(i,t)\ \text{treated}}[\, Y_{itr} - \hat{Y}_{itr}(0)\,] \qquad GF_r = 1 + \hat{\tau}_r / \bar{Y}_r^{\,0}$$

Imputation estimator of Borusyak, Jaravel & Spiess (2024). Y_{itr} = entrants in rank bin r, district i, half-year t; the first stage is fitted on **untreated cells only**, so no already-treated district is ever a control. $\bar{Y}_r^{\,0}$ is the mean of Y_{itr} over the adopters' untreated cells. **GF_r is the multiple of the pre-reform flow**: 1 is no change, 2 is twice as many entrants of that rank as the reform's absence would have brought.

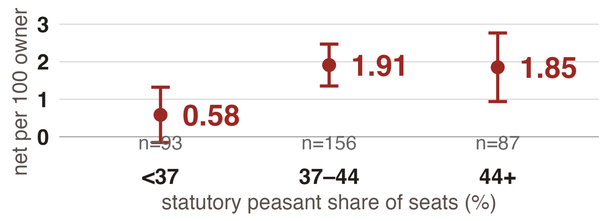
Who did the reform add to the administration

Rank the entrant already held	ATT (SE)	GF_r	95% CI	Pre-trend *p*
rank 1–4 — hereditary nobility earned in service	+0.118 (0.014)	**×9.8**	[7.7, 11.9]	0.78
rank 5–8 — personal nobility, not hereditary	+0.240 (0.071)	×2.2	[1.5, 2.9]	0.81
rank 9–14 — tax-exempt officials	+0.777 (0.140)	×2.3	[1.8, 2.8]	0.77
no rank recorded	+0.242 (0.077)	×2.6	[1.6, 3.6]	0.19

Based on Borusyak, Jaravel & Spiess (2024), "Revisiting Event-Study Designs: Robust and Efficient Estimation," *Review of Economic Studies* 91(6): 3253–3285.

5. Mechanisms

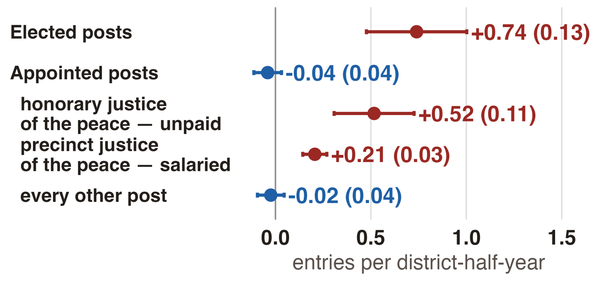
1 · Heterogeneity by franchise intensity. Districts where the enfranchisement of the peasantry went further are districts where the effect is stronger.



Net entry per 100 resident owners, by statutory peasant seat share. Bands as mapped in §3 (n = 93 / 156 / 87).

2 · Compensation. The reform did not come with a major increase in officials' pay. It is the office itself that held value for the elite.

2a · Elected, not appointed. Elected posts are paid locally, out of the taxes the assembly raises — when they are paid at all. The largest single response is an office that carried **no salary**. Every post that is not a justice of the peace is flat.



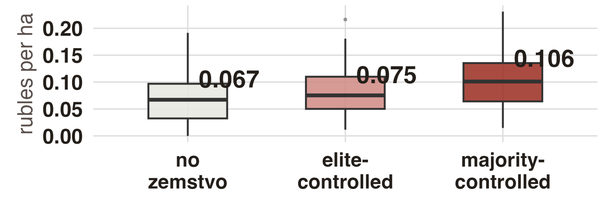
Estate-owner entry per district-half-year, 95% CI clustered by province. Pre-trends .10–.53.

2b · The crown disburses fewer privileges. As the elite walk into local office, the one thing the state controls — rank — is handed out less freely.

What it measures	ATT (SE)	% of mean
Promotions how often anyone is promoted at all	**−1.05 (0.32)**	**−18%**
Rungs of advancement how far those promotions carry, in classes	**−1.24 (0.24)**	**−25%**
Rungs per promotion how big a single step is	−0.13 (0.02)	−11%

Per district-half-year, 75,709 promotions. Pre-trends .64 / .92 / .97.

3 · The de facto tax burden on noble landed estates. Evidence from the nobles' own balance sheets — 215 estates, 1873. Where the nobility lost the assembly, their land paid more than half as much again.



Rubles per hectare, by who controls the assembly: 0.067 → 0.075 → **0.106**.

References. Besley & Persson (2011) *Pillars of Prosperity* · Borusyak, Jaravel & Spiess (2024) *REStud* · Castañeda Dower, Finkel, Gehlbach & Nafziger (2018) *APSR* · Nafziger (2011) *J.Ec.Hist.* · Acemoglu & Robinson (2000) *QJE*.
Sources. PSZ no. 40457; RGIA f. 1149 op. 6 d. 82B, f. 1159 op. 1 d. 215; *Senatskie vedomosti* 1860–1876; Tax Commission 1863.

Igor Kolesnikov igor_kolesnikov@berkeley.edu
Otto Kienitz okienit1@jhu.edu